What Is Stoicism?

What would it mean to live well, whatever happens to you?

READING · 10 MINUTES

Stoicism 101. Give a short talk in your own words, drawing on Stoicism 101, or watch this five-minute video together.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack a week ahead with the question above. Newcomers need no preparation.

Open · 15	Read · 10	Discuss · 40	Practice · 10	Close · 15
Ground rules; names and what brought you	Your short talk or the video	The questions below	Introduce it	Agree on a regular day and time

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Before tonight, what did you think “stoic” meant? What surprised you?
2. The Stoics said a good life depends on character, not circumstances. Do you believe that?
3. Think of someone you admire for how they handle hardship. What do they actually do?
4. Wisdom, courage, justice, temperance: which comes easiest to you? Which is hardest?
5. What would make a group like this worth your time each month?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Evening review. Each night, ask: What went well? What didn’t? What will I do differently tomorrow?

FACILITATOR’S MOVE

“What do you mean by…?” When someone says *good* or *happy*, ask them to define it first.

NOTES

What's in My Control?

Why do we spend so much energy on things we can't change?

READING · ONE PAGE

Epictetus, *Enchiridion* 1. Some things are up to us: our judgments, intentions, and actions. Others aren't: our bodies, reputations, and other people.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack a week ahead with the question above and a link to the reading.

Open · 10	Read · 10	**Discuss · 45**	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	Aloud, together	**The questions below**	Try it on a real worry	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. List what worried you this week. Which items were fully up to you?
2. Is your health in your control? Your job? Where exactly is the line?
3. If outcomes aren't up to us, why try at all?
4. What changes when you aim at your effort rather than the result?
5. Where could this idea go wrong if it's taken too far?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Mine / not mine. Once a day, split a worry into the part that's yours and the part that isn't. Act only on yours.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"How would you know?" When someone says something is out of their control, ask how they'd tell.

NOTES

Anger

Is it the thing that happened, or what I tell myself about it?

READING · TWO SHORT PASSAGES

Epictetus, *Enchiridion* 5: we aren't disturbed by things, but by our judgments about them. **Seneca, *On Anger* 2.4** (Book II, chapter 4): anger comes in three movements: an involuntary jolt, a judgment we agree to, and a passion we can't control. We can step in at the second.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack. Ask people to notice one moment of irritation during the week.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	Aloud, together	The questions below	Rewrite one judgment	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Recall a recent moment of anger. What happened, and what did you tell yourself about it?
2. Seneca says the first jolt isn't up to us, but agreeing to it is. In your example, where could you have stepped in?
3. Seneca thought anger is never useful. Do you agree?
4. What's the difference between anger and a firm, fair response?
5. What would a pause change: counting, walking away, sleeping on it?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Catch the second movement. When you feel the jolt, finish the sentence "I'm telling myself that…" before you act. Then ask whether it's true.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"Can you give an example?" Talk about anger stays vague until someone describes a real moment.

NOTES

Worry About the Future

Do we suffer more from what happens, or from what we imagine?

READING · TWO PAGES

Seneca, Letter 13 (“On Groundless Fears”). Many fears never arrive; Seneca asks whether a feared evil is certain before we suffer it.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack with the question above. Link the letter; reading it ahead is optional.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	Key passages aloud	The questions below	Five quiet minutes	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. What future event takes up the most room in your head right now?
2. Think of past worries. How many happened the way you feared?
3. Seneca asks whether the evil is certain. Is that comforting, or dismissive?
4. What’s the difference between planning and worrying?
5. How could calmly imagining the worst help rather than hurt?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Rehearse a setback. For five minutes, calmly picture something going wrong, and plan how you’d respond well.

FACILITATOR’S MOVE

“If that’s true, what follows?” Walk a worry forward, step by step, to see where it really leads.

NOTES

Difficult People

How do I stay decent toward people who make it hard?

READING · ONE PARAGRAPH

Marcus Aurelius, *Meditations* 2.1. Each morning he expects to meet rude, ungrateful people, reminds himself they act from ignorance, and that we're made to work together.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack. Remind people to keep examples anonymous: no names, no workplaces.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; keep it anonymous	Aloud, twice	The questions below	Write your own 2.1	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Marcus expects difficult people every morning. Is that pessimistic or practical?
2. Think of someone who frustrates you. What might they believe that makes their behavior make sense to them?
3. Does understanding someone mean excusing them?
4. In that relationship, what is actually in your control?
5. What does justice ask of you toward people you don't like?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Morning preparation. Before work, say your own version of 2.1: who you might meet today, and how you want to treat them.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"Is that always true?" When someone says "people like that never change," invite a counterexample.

NOTES

MEETING GUIDE · GETTING STARTED

ABOUT 90 MINUTES

What's Actually Good?

If money, health, and reputation aren't the goal, what is?

READING · THREE PAGES

Plato, *Euthydemus* 278e–282e. Socrates argues that wealth and health only benefit us when they're used wisely, so wisdom is what makes anything good.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack with the question above and a link to the reading.

Open · 10	Read · 10	**Discuss · 45**	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	Key passages aloud	The questions below	Try it on a real choice	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Name three things you want most. Why do you want them?
2. Can wealth or health ever harm someone? How?
3. Socrates says wisdom is what makes other things useful. Do you agree?
4. The Stoics called money and health "preferred indifferents." What's gained and lost in that view?
5. Looking back on your meetings so far, what's one idea you've actually used?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

The wise-person test. Before a decision, ask: what would a wise person do here, and why?

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"Is that in your control?" Bring back the control question: are the things you want most up to you?

NOTES

A Deeper Introduction

What did the Stoics actually believe, and why?

READING · ONE OR TWO SECTIONS

Internet Encyclopedia of Philosophy, "Stoicism." A little dense, but rich and readable. Too long for one meeting? Pick one or two sections.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack. If you plan to read *How to Be a Stoic* next, tell members now so they can get a copy.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	Key passages aloud	The questions below	Choose your sentence	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Which idea in the article surprised you most?
2. The Stoics tied ethics to their physics and logic. Does how you see the world change how you should live?
3. Which idea from our first six months does the article help explain?
4. What would you still push back on?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

One sentence. Pick one sentence from the article that matters to you, and reread it each morning.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"What do you mean by…?" Words like *nature* and *reason* meant something specific to the Stoics.

NOTES

The Three Disciplines

How do you practice Stoicism, not just think about it?

READING · TWO SHORT ARTICLES

Donald Robertson, "Introduction to Stoicism: The Three Disciplines" and "A Simplified Modern Approach to Stoicism." Epictetus taught through desire, action, and judgment.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack with links to both articles.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	Key passages aloud	The questions below	Pick a daily practice	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Desire, action, and judgment: which discipline do you most need right now?
2. Which practices from earlier months fit under each discipline?
3. What gets in the way of daily practice for you?
4. How could this group help you keep at it?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

One daily practice. Choose one practice from Robertson's simplified approach and keep it all month.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"Can you give an example?" Ask for a moment this week when one of the disciplines would have helped.

NOTES

How to Be a Stoic, Part One

What does a modern Stoic life look like?

READING · FIRST HALF OF THE BOOK

Massimo Pigliucci, *How to Be a Stoic*. Modern Stoic theory and practice, organized around Epictetus' three disciplines.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Remind members which chapters to read. Some will only get partway; that's fine.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	A favorite passage each	The questions below	Start the journal	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Which of Pigliucci's examples comes closest to your own life?
2. Where does a modern reading change what Epictetus meant?
3. Where do you disagree with the author?
4. What would you ask him if he were here?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

A one-line journal. Each evening, write one line: where did you practice Stoicism today, and where did you miss?

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"How would you know?" Test the book's claims against members' own experience.

NOTES

How to Be a Stoic, Part Two

Which Stoic exercise is worth keeping?

READING · SECOND HALF OF THE BOOK

Pigliucci, *How to Be a Stoic*, second half. The last chapter is a guide to basic Stoic exercises, a natural bridge into practice.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack. Ask members to come ready to pick an exercise to try together next month.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	A favorite passage each	The questions below	Choose next month's exercise	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Which exercise in the final chapter appeals to you most? Which least?
2. Has your view of Stoicism changed since you started? How?
3. What does the book get right about living well that we haven't discussed?
4. Which exercise should we try together next month?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

One exercise. Choose one exercise from the final chapter and try it daily.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"Is that always true?" Test a favorite idea from the book against a hard case.

NOTES

A Practice Session

What happens when we practice together, not just talk?

INSTEAD OF A READING

Do the exercise together. Lead the exercise the group chose last month, such as the evening review, rehearsing a setback, or the view from above. More ideas in our practice resources.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack which exercise you'll do, so members can try it during the week.

Open · 10	Practice · 15	Discuss · 45	Plan · 10	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	The exercise, together	The questions below	How we'll keep it up	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. What did you notice during the exercise?
2. Was it harder or easier than you expected? Why?
3. Which practices have you kept up this year, and which did you drop?
4. How could the group support each other's practice between meetings?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Keep it going. Continue the exercise all month, and note one thing it changed.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"If that's true, what follows?" Follow each person's observation one step further.

NOTES

Looking Back, Looking Ahead

What has a year of Stoicism changed?

INSTEAD OF A READING

Bring a passage. Each member brings one passage from the year that stayed with them and reads it aloud.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack and ask everyone to bring a passage. This is the meeting where you plan year two.

Open · 10	Share · 20	Discuss · 35	Plan · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	Passages read aloud	The questions below	Choose year two's format	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Which idea have you used most this year?
2. What still feels hard to practice?
3. What kept you coming back?
4. What should our second year look like? See Topics and Formats for options.

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

A letter to yourself. As Seneca wrote to Lucilius, write a short letter to yourself to reread a year from now.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"Is that in your control?" Ask what each person can keep doing, whatever the group decides.

NOTES